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Can three big rail projects tap the state budget surplus? LA Metro thinks so.

December 2, 2022 | Pasadena Star-News: Web Edition Articles (CA)
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OpenURL Link

After a contentious debate, LA Metro Board voted on Thursday, Dec. 1 to prioritize requests for nearly $2 billion in state funds for three rail projects that would greatly impact the San Fernando Valley, San Gabriel Valley and southeast Los Angeles County.

The board will submit its application next week to the California State Transportation Agency with high expectations the state agency will deliver significant money to help build two new rail projects and extend another, aiming to reduce freeway traffic and air pollution by converting drivers into rail passengers.

The No. 1 priority project is the East San Fernando Valley (ESFV) Light Rail Transit Project. Metro is asking the state for $600 million which could complete funding for the project, which is set to break ground on Friday, Dec. 2.

The groundbreaking — for utility work on the first segment of the line — is expected to draw outgoing Mayor Eric Garcetti, L.A. City Councilmember Monica Rodriguez and Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel to celebrate the first rail project in the San Fernando Valley since the Red Line subway was extended to North Hollywood more than two decades ago, in 2000.

Metro's board accepted a staff plan on Thursday to ask the state for a total of $1.9 billion spread over the three rail projects that Metro believes are the most likely to get state dollars. Grants would fully fund some projects, while moving another toward full funding.

"The San Fernando Valley has long felt left behind by this agency," said Los Angeles City Councilmember and Metro board member Paul Krekorian, who said that out of about 100 rail stations in L.A. County, only two are in the vast San Fernando Valley. Krikorian said the money is required in order to hold onto about $908 million that the project was awarded from the federal government.

Krekorian whole-heartedly supported the board's decision that the Valley project be its No. 1 priority, saying: "If we don't get that state funding, we will lose that money. That should be our No. 1 priority."

The state has made available about $2.83 billion for LA Metro and possibly $4 billion unsecured dollars for the entire state in the next few years that have not been earmarked. The funding pots are leftover from a big $98 billion state budget surplus.

Metro will submit its application by Dec. 6. The state agency will announce the grants and amounts on Jan. 31, 2023, said Metro officials.

Metro's funding application, from highest amounts to lowest amounts sought:

Metro L (Gold) Line Foothill Extension Light Rail Transit Project ($798 million), is ranked as No. 2 priority. This would fully fund a 3.2-mile extension from Pomona to Claremont, and to the most eastern terminus of the line in Montclair, just over the Los Angeles County border in San Bernardino County. It would be the first Metro rail project to cross into another county, with the goal of easing gridlock from Inland Empire commuters who travel the 10, 210 and 60 freeways in and out of L.A. County. The Claremont-to-Montclair portion is scheduled to be paid for by the San Bernardino County Transportation Authority.

East San Fernando Valley (ESFV) Light Rail Transit Project ($600 million), is ranked as No. 1. The project's 9.2-mile route would connect the LA Metro's east-west G Line (Orange) at the Van Nuys Station with the Metrolink Station in

Sylmar/San Fernando. The first phase would travel 6.7 miles along the center median of Van Nuys Boulevard to San Fernando Road. A second phase continues northwest another 2.5 miles along the Metrolink rail line. It would be the first light-rail system entirely in the San Fernando Valley.

West Santa Ana Branch (WSAB) Transit Corridor Project ($500 million), is ranked No. 3. The 19.3-mile light-rail line would take riders from Artesia to downtown Los Angeles. The $9.1 billion project would follow the old right of way once used by the Pacific Electric line's Santa Ana route in L.A. County, which is how it got its modern day "Santa Ana" name. The line would run through Artesia, Cerritos, Bellflower, Paramount, Downey, South Gate, Cudahy, Bell, Huntington Park, Vernon, unincorporated Florence-Graham and eventually, to Union Station in downtown Los Angeles.

L.A. County Fourth District Supervisor and Metro board member Janice Hahn wanted to double the amount asked for the Artesia-to-L.A. line, saying she got a letter of support to submit a $1 billion request from Anthony Rendon, speaker of the California State Assembly.

Hahn said the staff agreed the project needed at least $1 billion from the state. The line has a 2035 completion date.

But Metro staff said the state might reject an inflated request for funds, jeopardizing an award. Others on the board said they trusted the staff not get too greedy.

"My concern is, by asking for too much (for the West Santa Ana Branch line), you will be jeopardizing the whole pot of money," said Fifth District Supervisor and board member Kathryn Barger.

Glendale City Councilmember and Metro board chairman Ari Najarian said "I don't want to overreach" as Metro competes with other transportation agencies in Southern California.

With only Whittier City Councilmember Fernando Dutra on her side, Hahn withdrew her motion.

Tim Sandoval, Pomona mayor and board member for the San Gabriel Valley cities, said he supported all three projects. He said the Gold (L Line) extension project has been in the works since 2009 and should be funded because it has been environmentally approved and is ready to go. It is unique because it would allow Inland Empire commuters to ride a light-rail line to Pasadena and Los Angeles.

"We believe that the Foothill Gold Line is in an excellent position to compete well against other projects in Southern California," said Habib Balian, CEO of the Foothill Gold Line Construction Authority, in a prepared statement. "The project is construction-ready and can be completed within the necessary timeframe, and therefore can start creating jobs and economic benefits for our region and the state."

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Scauzillo, S. (2022, December 2). Can three big rail projects tap the state budget surplus? LA Metro thinks so.*Pasadena Star-News: Web Edition Articles (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/18E28D0CEA8D3040.